

Topic D1: Britain and Ireland, 1867-1922

The main focus of this topic is on the changing relationship between Britain and Ireland in this period. Students will be expected to know about the reasons for the emergence of Irish nationalism and the ways in which it challenged the traditional relationship with Britain. Students will be expected to know about the development of Unionism and impact this had on Anglo-Irish politics. They should appreciate the reasons for and the extent of the polarisation of views regarding a constitutional settlement in Ireland.

It should be appreciated that the bullet points should not be taken as discrete entities. There are many ways in which they impact upon each other and mesh together. Thus, for example, the response to Home Rule in mainland Britain (bullet 2) had an impact on political developments in Ireland (bullet 3). The emergence of the Fenian Movement (bullet 1) as an agency for planning insurrection permeates bullet points 3 and 4. Throughout, the polarisation of attitudes towards Ireland and of politics in Ireland was to have a profound impact on political events.

The first bullet point, the challenge of nationalism from 1867-85, relates to the reasons for the growth of constitutional and revolutionary nationalism in the period. Students will be expected to understand the importance of land tenure and the significance of agricultural depression in Ireland in the 1870s; about Michael Davitt and Charles Stewart Parnell in the formation and impact of the Land League and about the attempts of the Government at land reform, including the Land Acts of 1870 and 1881 and Irish reaction to these attempts. Students will be expected to understand why Gladstone's attempts to 'pacify' Ireland, 1868-1874, failed. Students should know about the emergence of the Fenian movement and about the growing tensions in the 1880s resulting in the Coercion Act 1881, the Kilmainham Treaty, and the Phoenix Park murders of 1882 and the terrorist campaign waged on the British mainland.

The second bullet point, Home Rule objectives and unionist responses in Britain 1886-1914, relates to the impact of the campaign for Home Rule and opposition towards it. Students should know about the emergence of the Irish Home Rule Party, the role played by Charles Stewart Parnell and his impact on British politics. Students should also know about Gladstone's conversion to Home Rule and its impact on the Liberal Party. They should know why the first Home Rule Bill (1886) and the second Home Rule Bill (1893) failed. Students should know about the opposition to Home Rule and the emergence of Unionism, including the significance of Joseph Chamberlain and Lord Randolph Churchill. Students should have an understanding of the reasons for the introduction of the Third Home Rule Bill of 1912, about opposition to it by Andrew Bonar Law and the Unionists, and about the impact of the outbreak of war in August 1914 on the bill. Students will not be expected to know about issues in British political history 1903-14 which do not relate to the Home Rule question.

The third bullet point relates to divisions within Ireland on Home Rule and independence, 1886-1914, and refers to the response in Ireland to the campaign for Home Rule. Students should know about the significance of the leadership of John Redmond and about the role played by Arthur Griffiths and the foundation of Sinn Féin. Students should appreciate the importance of the development of cultural nationalism including the creation of the Gaelic League and Gaelic Athletic Association. Students should know about the existence of Unionism in the south of Ireland and the strength of the Unionist cause in Ulster. In this context, students should know about the roles played by Edmund Carson and James Craig. They should know about the reactions in Ireland to the third Home Rule Bill, and the creation of the Ulster Volunteer Force and the Catholic Irish Volunteers in 1912. Students should know about the stance of the British Army in Ireland and the Curragh Mutiny of 1914.